



AI PM LAB

— by TRIGOSAT CONSULTING —

FREE PRACTICAL GUIDE | 2026 EDITION

25 Instructions That Improve Almost Any AI Answer

Reusable instructions for roles, checklists, executive summaries, critique, red teaming, comparison, step-by-step planning, decision matrices, and human review.

Use one instruction at a time - or combine several into a professional work request.

DIRECT

Tell the AI how to work.

CONTROL

Make assumptions and limits visible.

REVIEW

Keep authority and accountability human.



Improve the instruction, not just the wording.

These lines can be added to an existing prompt to change the structure, depth, challenge level, or review quality of the answer.

- Start with the work outcome: what decision, action, communication, or deliverable should the answer support?
- Add only the instructions that materially improve the task. More instructions do not automatically create a better answer.
- Replace every bracketed field with your real audience, criteria, sources, constraints, and approval boundaries.
- For high-impact work, require verification and human approval before the output is used.

A simple combination might look like this:

```
Act as an operations analyst supporting a small business.  
Use only the information provided and flag missing data.  
Compare the three options using the same criteria.  
Explain the trade-offs and build a weighted decision matrix.  
Before finalizing, identify the items that require human approval.
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The result is still one prompt - but each instruction gives the AI a clearer operating rule.



A role is a perspective - not authority.

The best role names describe the work the AI should support, the responsibilities it should focus on, and the limits it must respect.

ROLE	USEFUL FOCUS
Business analyst	Compare information, identify patterns, clarify assumptions, and support decisions.
Operations analyst	Review workflows, bottlenecks, ownership, handoffs, and practical improvements.
Meeting coordinator	Create agendas, organize decisions, actions, owners, deadlines, and open questions.
Project planning assistant	Structure milestones, dependencies, risks, responsibilities, and status updates.
Research assistant	Find, organize, compare, and summarize evidence while stating sources and uncertainty.
Quality reviewer	Critique a draft against defined criteria and identify missing or risky elements.
SOP writer	Turn an approved process into clear steps, exceptions, escalation, and completion checks.
Customer communication editor	Improve clarity, tone, structure, and action without inventing commitments.
Decision-support analyst	Compare options, explain trade-offs, surface uncertainty, and prepare a recommendation.

Better role instruction:

Act as a decision-support analyst. Compare the vendor proposals using the approved criteria, show missing evidence, and prepare a provisional recommendation. Do not make the final selection or create terms not contained in the proposals.

Avoid: "Act as the world's best CEO and tell me exactly what to do."



Choose the type of improvement you need.

The instructions are organized by the change they make to the AI's work.

CATEGORY	NUMBERS	PURPOSE
Role & Context	01-05	Define perspective, audience, questions, sources, and uncertainty.
Format & Structure	06-10	Create checklists, summaries, step-by-step explanations, comparisons, and matrices.
Analysis & Challenge	11-15	Critique, red-team, pre-mortem, test trade-offs, and challenge conclusions.
Planning & Operations	16-20	Prioritize, assign actions, phase work, analyze bottlenecks, and create versions.
Quality & Control	21-25	Show sources, verify calculations, test criteria, flag approvals, and define next actions.

You can combine instructions from different categories, but keep the final prompt coherent and free of conflicting rules.



01 ROLE & CONTEXT

Assign a Relevant Working Role

Use it when: You need the AI to apply the lens, vocabulary, and priorities of a specific function.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Act as a [RELEVANT ROLE] supporting [TASK]. Focus on [RESPONSIBILITIES], use [APPROVED INPUTS], and stay within these boundaries: [LIMITS].

What it changes: Creates a useful working perspective without pretending the AI has real authority.

Watch for: Avoid vague status claims such as 'world-class expert.' A role is a lens, not a credential.

02 ROLE & CONTEXT

Name the Real Audience

Use it when: Tone, detail, and recommendations depend on who will use the result.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Prepare the output for [AUDIENCE]. They already know [BACKGROUND], care most about [PRIORITIES], and need to [DECIDE / ACT / UNDERSTAND].

What it changes: Makes the response more relevant, readable, and decision-oriented.

Watch for: Do not rely only on job titles; include what the audience knows and needs.



03 ROLE & CONTEXT

Ask Clarifying Questions First

Use it when: The request is ambiguous or missing information that would materially change the answer.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Before producing the output, ask up to five questions that would materially improve accuracy or usability. Do not ask for information already provided.

What it changes: Prevents the AI from filling important gaps with generic assumptions.

Watch for: Use this selectively; simple tasks should not become an unnecessary interview.

04 ROLE & CONTEXT

Limit the Source Material

Use it when: Accuracy matters and the AI should not rely on outside assumptions.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Use only the information provided below. If a necessary fact is missing, conflicting, or unclear, label it 'To confirm' instead of inventing it.

What it changes: Improves traceability and reduces unsupported facts.

Watch for: The AI can still misread the source, so verify the final output.



05 ROLE & CONTEXT

Separate Facts, Assumptions, and Recommendations

Use it when: You need to distinguish evidence from interpretation and advice.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Separate the response into: Confirmed facts, Assumptions, Analysis, Recommendations, and Items requiring verification.

What it changes: Makes uncertainty visible and supports better human review.

Watch for: A labeled assumption is still an assumption, not evidence.

06 FORMAT & STRUCTURE

Return a Checklist

Use it when: The output must support consistent execution or review.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Convert the information into a checklist. Use one action per line, logical sequence, clear completion criteria, and a final verification step.

What it changes: Turns narrative information into something easier to use repeatedly.

Watch for: Check that complex judgment is not reduced to an oversimplified checkbox.



07 FORMAT & STRUCTURE

Create an Executive Summary

Use it when: A decision-maker needs the essential information without the full detail.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Create an executive summary with: purpose, key findings, material risks, decisions needed, and recommended next actions. Keep it under [LENGTH].

What it changes: Prioritizes decision-relevant information and reduces noise.

Watch for: Verify that important caveats were not removed for brevity.

08 FORMAT & STRUCTURE

Explain It Step by Step

Use it when: The sequence, logic, or method matters.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Explain the process step by step. For each step include: purpose, required input, action, expected output, and common failure point.

What it changes: Makes the reasoning process and operational sequence easier to follow.

Watch for: A step-by-step answer can sound certain even when the underlying information is weak.



09 FORMAT & STRUCTURE

Compare Options Consistently

Use it when: You need a fair comparison instead of separate descriptions.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Compare the options using the same criteria: [CRITERIA]. Use a table with evidence, advantages, disadvantages, risks, and missing information.

What it changes: Reduces inconsistent evaluation and makes trade-offs visible.

Watch for: The quality of the comparison depends on the quality of the criteria.

10 FORMAT & STRUCTURE

Build a Decision Matrix

Use it when: Several options must be evaluated using weighted criteria.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Create a decision matrix using these criteria and weights: [CRITERIA + WEIGHTS]. Show evidence, score, weighted score, uncertainty, and total.

What it changes: Creates a transparent structure for comparing alternatives.

Watch for: Weights are human judgments; the matrix supports the decision but does not make it objective.

**11 ANALYSIS & CHALLENGE****Critique the Draft**

Use it when: You want to identify weaknesses before finalizing a document, plan, or message.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Critique the draft for clarity, completeness, evidence, logic, usability, tone, and risk. Identify the three most important improvements before rewriting.

What it changes: Produces targeted revision instead of superficial polishing.

Watch for: Ask the AI to preserve valid content rather than rewriting everything automatically.

12 ANALYSIS & CHALLENGE**Red-Team the Proposal**

Use it when: You need a deliberate challenge to a plan, strategy, or recommendation.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Red-team this proposal. Identify hidden assumptions, failure points, stakeholder objections, unintended consequences, and evidence that could disprove the recommendation.

What it changes: Surfaces weaknesses that supportive analysis may miss.

Watch for: Red teaming should improve the proposal, not create negativity without prioritization.

**13 ANALYSIS & CHALLENGE****Run a Pre-Mortem**

Use it when: You want to identify likely causes of failure before execution.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Assume this initiative failed six months from now. Identify likely causes, early warning signs, consequences, preventive actions, and contingency actions.

What it changes: Turns possible failure into practical risk preparation.

Watch for: Prioritize the most plausible risks rather than generating an unlimited list.

14 ANALYSIS & CHALLENGE**Explain the Trade-Offs**

Use it when: A recommendation has benefits, costs, or competing priorities.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Explain the main trade-offs. For each option show what improves, what worsens, what remains uncertain, and who is most affected.

What it changes: Prevents recommendations from appearing cost-free or universally beneficial.

Watch for: Make sure stakeholder impacts are based on evidence rather than stereotypes.

**15 ANALYSIS & CHALLENGE****Test the Opposite Conclusion**

Use it when: You want to reduce confirmation bias.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Build the strongest reasonable case against the current conclusion. Then explain what evidence would favor each side and what would change the recommendation.

What it changes: Encourages more balanced evaluation and identifies decision thresholds.

Watch for: Not every position deserves equal weight; compare evidence quality.

16 PLANNING & OPERATIONS**Prioritize by Impact and Effort**

Use it when: A task list or improvement backlog is too large.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Prioritize the items using an impact-versus-effort matrix. Classify each as quick win, major project, fill-in task, or low priority, and explain the classification.

What it changes: Creates a practical sequence for limited time and capacity.

Watch for: Impact and effort estimates should be validated by the people doing the work.



17 PLANNING & OPERATIONS

Turn Notes into an Action Tracker

Use it when: You need clear responsibilities and follow-up from unstructured notes.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Convert the notes into an action tracker with: action, owner, deadline, dependency, status, and next checkpoint. Use 'To confirm' for missing fields.

What it changes: Transforms discussion into visible, accountable work.

Watch for: Do not let the AI assign owners or deadlines that were never agreed.

18 PLANNING & OPERATIONS

Create a Phased Plan

Use it when: A goal needs to be broken into manageable implementation stages.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Create a phased plan with: phase objective, activities, owner, inputs, deliverables, dependencies, risks, and completion criteria.

What it changes: Connects high-level goals to execution and control.

Watch for: Check that phases reflect real capacity, approval points, and constraints.



19 PLANNING & OPERATIONS

Identify Bottlenecks and Handoffs

Use it when: A process feels slow, repetitive, or difficult to coordinate.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Analyze the workflow for waiting time, duplicate work, unclear handoffs, rework, missing ownership, and steps that may be simplified or automated.

What it changes: Focuses improvement on flow and responsibility instead of adding more tools.

Watch for: Automation is not automatically the best solution; clarify the process first.

20 PLANNING & OPERATIONS

Create Three Practical Versions

Use it when: Different audiences or situations need different levels of detail or tone.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Create three versions: concise, standard, and detailed. Preserve the same facts and core recommendation in each version.

What it changes: Makes one approved message adaptable without changing its substance.

Watch for: Verify that the short version does not remove a required warning or condition.

**21 QUALITY & CONTROL****State Sources and Uncertainty**

Use it when: The answer involves research, changing information, or incomplete evidence.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

For each important claim, state the source or provided evidence, the date when relevant, and the confidence level. Clearly mark anything not verified.

What it changes: Improves transparency and reduces false certainty.

Watch for: A confidence label is not a substitute for a reliable source.

22 QUALITY & CONTROL**Verify Calculations and Show the Method**

Use it when: The output includes numbers, estimates, percentages, or comparisons.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Show the calculation method, define each input, verify the arithmetic, and identify assumptions. Present the result and a short reasonableness check.

What it changes: Makes quantitative work easier to audit and correct.

Watch for: Always recalculate high-impact figures independently.



23 QUALITY & CONTROL

Check Against Acceptance Criteria

Use it when: You know what a successful output must contain.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Before finalizing, check the response against these acceptance criteria: [CRITERIA]. Report any criterion not fully met and revise where possible.

What it changes: Turns quality from a vague impression into a review step.

Watch for: Weak criteria produce weak validation; make them specific and observable.

24 QUALITY & CONTROL

Flag Human Approval Points

Use it when: The work can create commitments, risk, or high-impact decisions.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

Identify every element that requires human approval, qualified review, or authority before use. Explain why and name the appropriate decision owner if provided.

What it changes: Keeps decision rights visible and prevents silent delegation to AI.

Watch for: The AI cannot determine organizational authority unless you provide it.



25 QUALITY & CONTROL

Finish with the Next Best Action

Use it when: An answer is informative but may not be actionable.

COPY THIS INSTRUCTION

End with: the recommended next action, who should own it, what input is needed, the decision deadline, and what should be verified first.

What it changes: Connects the answer to real workflow execution.

Watch for: Do not accept an invented owner or deadline; confirm both.

BUILD A COMBINED INSTRUCTION**Use this structure when several controls are needed.****ROLE**

Act as [ROLE] supporting [TASK].

CONTEXT

Prepare the output for [AUDIENCE] using only [APPROVED INPUTS].

METHOD

[COMPARE / CRITIQUE / RED-TEAM / PRIORITIZE / PLAN].

FORMAT

Return [CHECKLIST / SUMMARY / TABLE / MATRIX / ACTION PLAN].

CONTROL

Separate facts from assumptions, flag missing information, and identify human approval points.

NEXT STEP

End with the recommended next action and what must be verified first.

Tip: Do not use every instruction in every task. Select the smallest combination that improves the work.



Better instructions do not remove the need for review.

Use this checklist when the output affects clients, money, timelines, employees, public communication, compliance, or business commitments.

☐	Every important factual statement can be traced to an approved source.
☐	Names, dates, numbers, calculations, and links have been checked.
☐	Facts, assumptions, interpretations, and recommendations are separated.
☐	The AI did not create an owner, deadline, policy, price, or commitment without authority.
☐	Sensitive or confidential information is handled appropriately.
☐	The output meets the defined acceptance criteria and is usable by the intended audience.
☐	High-impact content has been reviewed by the accountable person or qualified specialist.
☐	The next action, decision owner, and verification step are clear.

Core rule: AI can support analysis, drafting, planning, and review. It should not silently own decisions, authority, or consequences.



Use the instructions to improve one answer. Then improve the workflow around it.

Choose one recurring task in your business or team - a client email, weekly plan, meeting recap, vendor comparison, project update, analysis, or decision - and build a reusable prompt with clear inputs, outputs, boundaries, and human review.

EXPLORE MORE FREE RESOURCES OR REQUEST A MINI WORKFLOW REVIEW

<https://aipmlab.propertydex.xyz>

Related AI PM Lab resources:

- Before You Prompt: The Clarity Checklist
- The One Prompt Framework You Actually Need
- From Vague Request to Professional Prompt
- 20 Professional Prompts for Everyday Work

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